

MODULE 3: LANGUAGE FOCUS PRIME LANGUAGE ACADEMY

Le Plus-que-Parfait (The Past Perfect)

This handout will explain the French past perfect tense, "le plus-que-parfait."

Situations d'Utilisation (Situations of Use):

- On utilise le plus-que-parfait pour parler d'une action qui s'est produite **avant une autre action déjà située dans le passé.**

- Grammatical Structure:

Le plus-que-parfait est formé avec l'auxiliaire **"être"** ou **"avoir"** (conjugué à l'imparfait) + le participe passé du verbe principal. (The past perfect is formed with the auxiliary verb **"be"** or **"have"** (conjugated in **the past tense**) + **the past participle** of the main verb.)

- Avec "être"** : Utilisé avec les verbes qui décrivent un mouvement ou un changement d'état (par exemple, aller, venir, naître, mourir). (**With "be"**: Used with verbs that describe movement or a change of state (e.g., go, come, born, die).)
- Avec "avoir"** : Utilisé avec la plupart des autres verbes. (**With "have"**: Used with most other verbs.)

1: Affirmative Form

Situations of Use (Situations d'Utilisation):

- We use the past perfect to talk about an action that happened **before another past action.**

Grammatical Structure:

- The past perfect simple:** **Subject** + **Auxiliary verb(had/was-were)** + **Past participle**
- Subject**
- Auxiliary verb ("to be" or "to have") conjugated in the imperfect tense**
- Past participle of the main verb**

"To be" is used with verbs that describe:

- Movement** (to go, to come)
- Change of state** (to be born, to die)

"To have" is used with most other verbs.

Examples

- I had left** (j'étais parti) **before she arrived.** (**avant** qu'elle arrive) (**être** with partir)
- She had finished** (elle avait fini) her homework (ses devoirs) **when I came home.** (quand je suis rentré) (**avoir** with finir)
- We went** (nous sommes allés) **to the movies** (au cinéma) **after eating** (après avoir mangé). (**être** with aller, **avoir** with manger) **Note:** This example uses the passé composé (juxtaposed verbs) to show the second action in the past.
- They were born** (ils sont nés) **in 2000.** (en 2000) (**être** with naître)

2: Negative Form

Situations of Use (Situations d'Utilisation):

Same as the affirmative form, to talk about an action that happened **before another past action**, but negated.

Grammatical Structure:

Not (ne) + auxiliary verb (conjugated in the imperfect tense) + **not** (pas) + past participle of the main verb.

Examples:

1. **I hadn't left** (je n'étais pas parti) **before she arrived**. (avant qu'elle arrive)
2. **She hadn't finished** (elle n'avait pas fini) her homework (ses devoirs) **when I came home**. (quand je suis rentré)
3. **We didn't go** (nous ne sommes pas allés) to the movies (au cinéma) **after eating** (après avoir mangé).
4. **They weren't born** (ils ne sont pas nés) in 2000. (en 2000)

3: Interrogative Form (Forme Interrogative)

How to Form a Question:

- To form a question in the past perfect, invert the subject and the auxiliary verb.
- Use "Est-ce que..." (Is it that...) before the inverted subject and auxiliary verb for emphasis.

Examples:

Est-ce que j'étais parti avant qu'elle arrive? (Had I left before she arrived?)

Étais-je parti avant qu'elle arrive? (Had I left before she arrived?)

More Examples:

- **Étais-tu sorti** avec elle **avant** le film ? (**Had you gone out with her before the movie?**)
- **Avaient-ils voyagé** en Europe **avant** de venir ici ? (**Had they traveled to Europe before coming here?**)
- **Étions-nous allés** à la plage **avant** la tempête ? (**Had we gone to the beach before the storm?**)

4: Negative Interrogative Form (Forme Interrogative Négative)

How to Form a Negative Question:

- Use the same structure as the negative form (negative auxiliary verb + pas + past participle), but start with "Est-ce que..." (Is it that...)

Example:

Est-ce que je **n'**étais pas parti avant qu'elle arrive? (Had**n't** I left before she arrived?)

More Examples:

- **N'**étais-tu pas sorti avec elle avant le film ? (**Hadn't you gone out with her before the movie?**)
- **N'**avaient-ils pas voyagé en Europe avant de venir ici ? (**Hadn't they traveled to Europe before coming here?**)
- **N'**étions-nous pas allés à la plage avant la tempête ? (**Hadn't we gone to the beach before the storm?**)

5: Active Voice vs. Passive Voice (Voix Active et Voix Passive)

- The past perfect can be used in both the active and passive voice.
- **Active Voice Example:**
- J'avais lu le livre avant qu'elle ne me le prête. (I **had read the book before she lent it to me.**)
- **Passive Voice Example:**
- Le livre avait été lu avant que je ne l'emprunte. (**The book had been read before I borrowed it.**)
- **Note:** The passive voice in the past perfect is formed with:

- "Être" conjugated in the imperfect tense (e.g., j'étais, tu étais, il/elle était, etc.)
- Past participle of the verb
- "par"

- **Here are some additional points to consider:**

- The active voice emphasizes the doer of the action (e.g., I read the book).

- The passive voice emphasizes the recipient of the action (e.g., The book was read).

- Not all verbs can be used in the passive voice.

- **More Examples:**

Active Voice

- Nous avons préparé le dîner avant que les invités arrivent. (We **had prepared** dinner *before* the guests arrived.)
- Elle avait écrit la lettre avant de l'envoyer. (She **had written** the letter *before* sending it.)
- Ils avaient construit la maison en un an. (They **had built** the house *in* a year.)

Passive Voice

- Le dîner avait été préparé avant l'arrivée des invités. (Dinner had been prepared *before* the guests arrived.)
- La lettre avait été écrite avant d'être envoyée. (The letter had been written *before* being sent.)
- La maison avait été construite en un an. (The house had been built *in* a year.)

Worksheet

This worksheet will help you practice using the past perfect tense in English, also known as the "pluperfect" tense.

Instructions:

1. Read the handout on the past perfect tense (provided separately).
2. Complete the following exercises.

Exercise 1: Affirmative Form

Fill in the blanks with the correct past participle of the verb in parentheses.

1. I had (go) to the store before it closed.
2. She had (finish) her homework when I came home.
3. We had..... (leave) for vacation before the rain.
4. They were (be born) in 2000.
5. You had (take) the bus before class.

Exercise 2: Negative Form

Rewrite the following sentences in the negative form (had not + past participle).

1. I had left before she arrived. ->
2. She had finished her homework when I came home. ->
3. We went to the movies after eating. ->
4. They were born in 2000. ->
5. You had taken the bus before class. ->

Exercise 3: Interrogative Form

Write questions in the past perfect tense using "Had."

1. I left before she arrived.
3. you finished your homework before leaving.
4. she gone out with him before the movie.
5. we played all day before going home.
6. they traveled to Europe before coming here.

Exercise 4: Negative Interrogative Form

Write questions in the negative past perfect tense using "Hadn't."

1. I left before she arrived.
2. you finished your homework before leaving.
3. she gone out with him before the movie.
4. we played all day before going home.
5. they traveled to Europe before coming here.

Exercise 5: Active vs. Passive Voice

Rewrite the following sentences in the passive voice.

1. I had read the book before she lent it to me. ->
2. They had built the house in a year. ->

Bonus Challenge:

Write a short paragraph in English using the past perfect tense to describe what happened before a specific event in the past.

Example:

I had finished all my chores by the time my parents arrived home from work, so we were able to spend the evening together.

Dialogue

Setting: Two friends, Nadia and Liam, are catching up at a cafe.

Nadia: Hey Liam, so good to see you! How was your trip to Italy?

Liam: It was amazing, Nadia! But you wouldn't believe it - I'd lost my passport before I even left the house!

Nadia: Oh no! That sounds stressful. How did you manage?

Liam: Luckily, I had applied for a renewal a few weeks earlier, just in case. So, I was able to get an emergency passport issued before my flight.

Nadia: Phew, close call! What did you do first when you finally arrived in Italy?

Liam: Well, since I hadn't slept much the night before worrying about the passport, I went straight to a hotel and took a long nap.

Nadia: Makes sense! Did you get to see all the sights you wanted to?

Liam: Absolutely! I'd researched everything beforehand, so I knew exactly where to go. I even managed to squeeze in a cooking class I'd been wanting to take forever.

Nadia: That's awesome! Did you learn how to make any delicious Italian dishes?

Liam: (Smiling) I did! By the time I came back, I had perfected my pasta-making skills. Want me to cook you some dinner sometime?

Nadia: Absolutely! I can't wait to hear all about your trip in more detail.

Text

A Walk Down Memory Lane

The old photo album lay open on my lap, its worn leather cover whispering stories of years gone by. As I turned each yellowed page, a flood of memories washed over me. Here I was, a carefree child, building sandcastles on the beach, the salty spray clinging to my hair. I had just learned to swim that summer, the fear replaced by exhilaration as I kicked my legs and conquered the waves.

Flipping through the pages, I saw a picture of my graduation day. I had meticulously ironed my cap and gown the night before, a nervous excitement bubbling in my stomach. All those years of studying had culminated in this moment, the key that would unlock my future. Now, years later, I couldn't help but smile at the naivety and hope in my younger self's eyes.

The album held more than just photos; it held fragments of life lived, experiences that had shaped me. There was a picture of my first apartment, a cramped space filled with mismatched furniture and overflowing bookshelves. I had saved for months to move out on my own, reveling in the independence and responsibility. Little did I know the challenges and lessons that awaited me in that tiny apartment.

As I closed the album, a sense of contentment settled over me. The past, with all its triumphs and tribulations, had brought me to this point. The experiences I had, the skills I had learned, the people I had met - they all formed the tapestry of who I was today. And while the future remained unwritten, I faced it with a heart full of gratitude for the journey that led me here.

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